

but includes the employer's *and* employee's cost) to other options such as purchasing insurance on your own or getting coverage on a spouse's plan.

9. Open an HSA (Health Savings Account) linked to a high-deductible insurance plan and take a tax deduction for your contributions, subject to limitations as stated in the federal tax law.

10. If your insurance company does not cover USPSTF-recommended tests, question why it doesn't cover expenses proven to prevent disease and start a letter-writing campaign asking for coverage; write your insurance company and your state's insurance commissioner.
11. Take a tax deduction for medical expenses that exceed 7.5% of your adjusted gross income (AGI).
12. Go to a provider (physician, physician extender, or hospital) that is in your insurance company's network so that you can take advantage of discounted rates already negotiated by your insurance company.



13. If the provider that you prefer is not in your insurance company's network, ask the provider to join so that you can get discounted rates.
14. Choose a high-performing health-care plan by checking out plan ratings by the National Commission on Quality Assurance (NCQA).
15. Select a physician who follows the standards of care according to evidence-based medicine; find those who meet the NCQA criteria in its searchable physician directory online (Recognition.ncqa.org).
16. Get free blood pressure, blood sugar, and cholesterol checks at health fairs. Take the results to your physician for discussion and further testing if needed.
17. Wait at least 24 hours after the onset of a fever (with no other worrisome symptoms) before making a doctor's appointment.
18. Take free or nominal-fee health classes on topics such as childbirth preparation and diabetes prevention; beware that some of these classes are sponsored by pharmaceutical companies.
19. Find free skin-cancer screenings but don't wait to find a free check